

GET OUT...
An anti-Hindi protest by DMK workers in Chennai

ANI

bother to learn Marathi.

Author and historian Manu S. Pillai says he doesn't see any reason why Hindi should receive "special state patronage". "It's a dated notion that nations must have a common language to stick together. We are a diverse country and instead of pushing our diversity into a political straitjacket, we should let all our languages thrive," he says.

AN IDEOLOGICAL PROJECT

G.N. Devy, cultural scholar and the man behind the People's Linguistic Survey of India, notes that the number of Hindi speakers in India is inflated, with "Hindi subsuming many smaller languages". According to the 2011 Census, the country had over 528 million Hindi speakers, but that figure combined 206 million people whose mother tongues had been grouped under Hindi, including Bhojpuri (51 million speakers), Chhattisgarhi (16 million) and Kumaoni (2 million). So, the actual number of native Hindi speakers is around 320 million. Considering that the census had a base of 1,210 million, this meant that at best a third of the population has Hindi as mother tongue. "How can 30 per cent of the population impose their will on the other 70 per cent? This is not right in any political modality," says Devy.



> **"ONLY 30 PER CENT OF THE POPULATION SPEAK HINDI, HOW CAN THEY IMPOSE THEIR WILL ON THE OTHER 70 PER CENT? THIS IS NOT RIGHT IN ANY POLITICAL MODALITY"**
>
> **G.N. DEVY,** *author of People's Linguistic Survey of India*

His questioning is in line with the perception that the BJP-RSS have long been pushing a unitarian model on India when it comes to religion, language and culture. Author-academician Apoorvanand says the "Hindi, Hindu, Hindustan" push was linked to the Hindutva project, but the emphasis on one language, one nation, one religion and one culture was in line with a European model of nationalism.

BJP national spokesperson Prem Shukla dismisses such criticism, saying the three-language policy has been in place since the 1960s, even before the birth of the present-day BJP. "The NEP has, in fact, liberalised language teaching by changing this to English, the local mother tongue, and another Indian language," he added, while denying claims that the BJP was trying to foist Hindi on anyone.

Apoorvanand notes that the three-language formula adopted in the 1960s was not based on pedagogic and educational principles. It was done to integrate the country by learning a language not spoken in that state. For instance, a Khasi speaker could learn Bengali, and a Bihari could learn Telugu. But the 'Hindi belt' adopted Hindi, English and Sanskrit as part of the formula, even as some southern states like Karnataka and Kerala were teaching Hindi voluntarily. "The Hindi states refuse to integrate with the non-Hindi-speaking states and their culture, but are now forcing the non-Hindi ones to integrate with them," Apoorvanand concludes.

Anil Shidore of the MNS points to other attempts to push the cultural dominance of Hindi. For instance, the Reserve Bank of India mandates that banks also conduct their business in the local language. The MNS had asked the Indian Banks' Association to provide such services and put up boards in Marathi and also launched a short-lived protest to ensure this was implemented. "This is part of the Sangh's 'soft power experiment', trying to attain cultural hegemony using entry points like curriculum, books, the education system," says Shidore.

In the end, it all comes down to whether groups and communities can respect each other and try not to straitjacket the other. In his book, *India: A Linguistic Civilisation*, Devy argues that the 'idea of India' can never be a singular one. "Plurality and diversity are its inalienable attributes," he points out. Amen to that. ■

—with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar